

UNIDCOM RIMS

UX/UI Audit — researcher portal, 9 September 2026

Portal build 73259d4 (round 4, 8 Sep) · v1 pilot feature set · 86 screens, 7 flows · Prepared 9 September 2026

The pilot’s core loop works end to end — every journey that could be run passed. Two defects still block onboarding: the desktop navigation is invisible to keyboard and screen-reader users, and a person page can show, and let an admin edit, the wrong researcher. Neither is a design choice; both are a day’s fix with a test.

Release verdict: NOT READY — 2 blockers and 9 high-priority findings open; task success is not the problem, legibility and reach are.

FINDINGS

43

2 sev-4 · 9 sev-3 · 26 sev-2 · 6 sev-1

TASK SUCCESS

100 %

7 of 7 runnable flows passed

BEST-PRACTICE SCORE

51 / 100

9 yes · 21 partial · 8 no of 38

The decision needed from you

Two deliberate August–September decisions carry a measurable usability bill: the one-to-one sidebar (25 rows, a third of them “Work in progress”) and the v1/v2 split that put DOI lookup behind the flag. Both are documented choices, not drift. This report prices them (\$4, \$5); revisiting them is a product call, not an engineering one.

1. What was audited, and how

The Flutter web portal at berlogabob.github.io/Unidcom-IADE, built from commit 73259d4 with the semantics tree on, in the three modes a user can be in — anonymous visitor, researcher, administrator — at desktop (1280 × 900) and phone (390 × 844) widths.

What	Source	Count
Screens captured (screenshot + accessibility tree each)	audit/2026-09-09-1136/screens.md	86
User journeys run end to end	flows-results.json — 2 not runnable: star an output (test account owns none), support requests (v2 only)	7 of 9
Provoked system states	cold start, wrong password, empty search, backend down at 3 s and 26 s	5
Review dimensions	Nielsen heuristics, UX laws, visual design, design system vs Figma, flows & states — plus orchestrator-verified findings	5 + 1
Best-practice checklist items scored	docs/research/2026-09-rims-best-practices.md, BP-01...38, each with a click-through or SQL test	38
Severity ≥ 3 claims re-tested before inclusion	2 corrected, 1 confirmed and promoted, 3 folded or dropped	6

Maestro, the repo’s E2E tool, could not drive Chromium on the audit machine (three attempts, driver never returned). The same journeys were run with Playwright; the scripts are committed under `audit/tools/` so the run is repeatable. The committed Maestro suite itself asserts text the build no longer shows (finding F-015).

2. The two blockers

Finding	Status	Evidence and cause
F-001 · Desktop navigation absent from the accessibility tree	Blocker	At ≥ 900 px none of the 25 sidebar rows, the mode switch or Sign out exists for assistive technology: 17 semantics nodes on the home page, 0 of them navigation. Verified after hover, keyboard focus, scroll, resize and reload. The phone drawer exposes every row correctly, so the defect is in the desktop layout branch.
F-002 · Person page keeps the previous researcher when only the id changes	Blocker	Two person URLs rendered byte-identical pages; after a hard reload the right person showed, and changing the id again kept the old one. Root cause: the page fetches once in <code>initState</code> and never on id change (<code>lib/public/person_page.dart:71</code>). An admin following a person-to-person link can edit the wrong record.

Both have a one-line fix and a one-test guard. Neither was visible to the existing tests, because no test renders the desktop shell at width or navigates person $\rightarrow$ person.

3. What a researcher will actually feel

Nine high-priority findings, in the order a researcher meets them.

ID	Where	What happens	Fix
F-007	Sidebar	25 rows in 6 groups; at 1280×900 only 11 fit before the fold, so Scientific Outputs is below it	Headers only by default; leaves on landing pages
F-008	Sidebar	The highlighted row is the wrong one on 6 of 25 pages (prefix match wins over exact)	Longest-match in <code>navSelected()</code>
F-009	My Outputs	A newly added output shows no pending tag — the researcher cannot tell what is approved	Reuse the existing status pill
F-005	Review queue	Reject fires with no confirmation, no reason, no feedback; Approve-all does confirm	Confirm + reason + Undo
F-003	Welcome pack	An anonymous visitor opening an M2 section hits a login wall instead of the promised redirect	Redirect to Getting started
F-004	Welcome pack	Signed-in and anonymous visitors get two different sidebars for the same page	One sidebar
F-006	404 page	Shows <code>GoException: no routes for location...</code> and drops the app shell	Friendly page inside the shell
F-010	Phone dashboard	KPI tiles clip at 390 px — key numbers unreadable	Wrap tiles
F-011	Logos page	Brand-colour swatch labels are illegible on their own swatch	Label outside the swatch

The remaining 32 findings (severity 2 and 1) are in `report.md`; the largest clusters are raw status enums shown to users (`draft`, `pending_review`, `a_confirmar`), mixed icon families including emoji, three accent colours on one KPI component, and a 20-second silent spinner before the (good) error message when the backend is unreachable.

4. Against best practice

The 38-item checklist distils what Pure, Converis, Elements, DSpace-CRIS and Haplo document, what CERIF, OpenAIRE and ORCID require, what FCT and CIÊNCIAVITAE ask of a unit, and the WCAG 2.2, GOV.UK and USWDS pattern rules that apply to forms and tables. Each item was tested by click-through or SQL on 9 September.

Met (9)		24 %
Partly met (21)		55 %
Not met (8)		21 %

Ahead of the field for its size. The data model — authorship as link rows with role and order, a unique DOI index, a full audit trail of 605 status changes — the approval gate that feeds a nightly, fail-closed public build (76 publications and 183 people on the site, matching the database), ORCID harvesting into a staging table for 26 researchers, and a real merge tool. Small units usually skip exactly these.

Behind every system surveyed. The entry experience:

Best practice	Status	What we have
BP-07 · Add output starts from a DOI/ORCID lookup	Not met	A blank six-field dialog; the Crossref client exists but sits behind the v2 flag, admin-only
BP-13 · Returned items carry a reviewer comment	Not met	Reject takes no reason; the item simply disappears from the researcher's list
BP-21 · Own list shows the workflow state as a text tag	Not met	No tag in My Outputs, although the pill component exists
BP-27 · Keyboard reach and 24 px targets	Not met	F-001; Reject is a 42 × 20 px text link
BP-16 · Duplicate check at entry (DOI, then ≈ 80 % title)	Partly	DOI is caught by the unique index; 8 duplicated normalised titles sit in the live table
BP-11/12 · Draft → submitted → validated, with withdraw	Partly	Outputs have no draft; a researcher's save is an immediate submission with no way back
BP-34/36 · FCT team export and data-quality counts	Partly	0 outputs flagged as representative; 1 466 unclaimed ORCID candidates not surfaced; CIÊNCIA ID coverage (25 of 184) not on the dashboard

5. Design criticism — built vs designed vs researched

Against the designer's templates. The tokens are faithful: navy sidebar, sand page, teal accent, 10 px radius, and the August contrast fix kept the brand teal while moving load-bearing text to the darker teal. The divergence is in components: template pills replaced by raw enum strings in five places, the template's icon set mixed with emoji in the Welcome pack, one KPI component in three accent colours, and a 404 page that drops the shell.

Against the research. Miller and Hick both argue for the six section headers as the visible menu, with leaves on the section landing pages — the model already has those pages. FCT's own guidance makes CIÊNCIA ID coverage and the five representative outputs the unit-level facts that matter; neither is on the dashboard. ORCID's display rules ask for the iD icon and the full URL; the profile shows a generic badge.

Drift, not decision. The sidebar semantics, the person-page refetch, the highlight logic, the stale Maestro suite and Reject-without-confirm were not chosen; each is a regression or omission that a test would have caught. That is the engineering message of this audit: the pilot needs a shell-width widget test and a navigate-A-to-B test more than it needs new features.

The public site is the stronger surface — fail-closed allowlists, ORCID links, sync green every night this week. Its open items are content (Portuguese bios under an English page, photos), not UX.

6. Recommended order of work

1. **F-001, F-002** — one day: fix both, pin each with a widget test.
2. **F-005, F-009, F-008** — one day: Reject confirm + reason + Undo; status pill in My Outputs; longest-match highlight.
3. **Sidebar** (F-007, F-023, F-035) — product decision with Rui, then half a day: headers-only default, mark WIP rows, fix the footer overlap.
4. **Welcome pack and 404** (F-003, F-004, F-006) — half a day.
5. **Phone** (F-010, F-036, F-037) — half a day.
6. **Regression suite** (F-015) — fix the six Maestro YAMLS and run them in CI, or adopt `audit/tools/flows.py`.
7. **BP-07 DOI-first entry, BP-16 title warning, BP-36 dashboard counts** — two days, the highest-value feature work before the demo.
8. **HEART instrumentation** — five events (`mode_chosen`, `profile_confirmed`, `output_added`, `candidate_claimed`, `review_decision`); three already exist in `change_log`.

7. Measurements for the next run

Metric	How measured	9 Sep 2026
Task success rate	7 runnable flows, all passed, 0 errors, 2 warnings	100 %
Mean steps per flow	tap/input count per journey	7.9
Findings by severity 4 / 3 / 2 / 1	<code>findings.json</code>	2 / 9 / 26 / 6
Severity - weighted score (Σ severity)	the number to drive down	93
Defect density	43 findings / 86 screens	0.50 per screen
Best-practice score	yes = 1, partial = ½, over 38 items	51 / 100
Researchers who can sign in	<code>people.orcid</code> filled — the adoption ceiling	26 of 184
Unclaimed ORCID candidates	<code>output_candidates.status = 'pending'</code>	1 466

Trend comparison is by (criterion, screen) pair between `findings.json` files; this is the first run, so there is no trend yet. Rerun: `audit/tools/README.md`. Screenshots and accessibility trees are kept out of git — they contain researcher emails from the admin data browser — and live only in the audit machine's `audit/2026-09-09-1136/screens` and `hierarchy` folders.

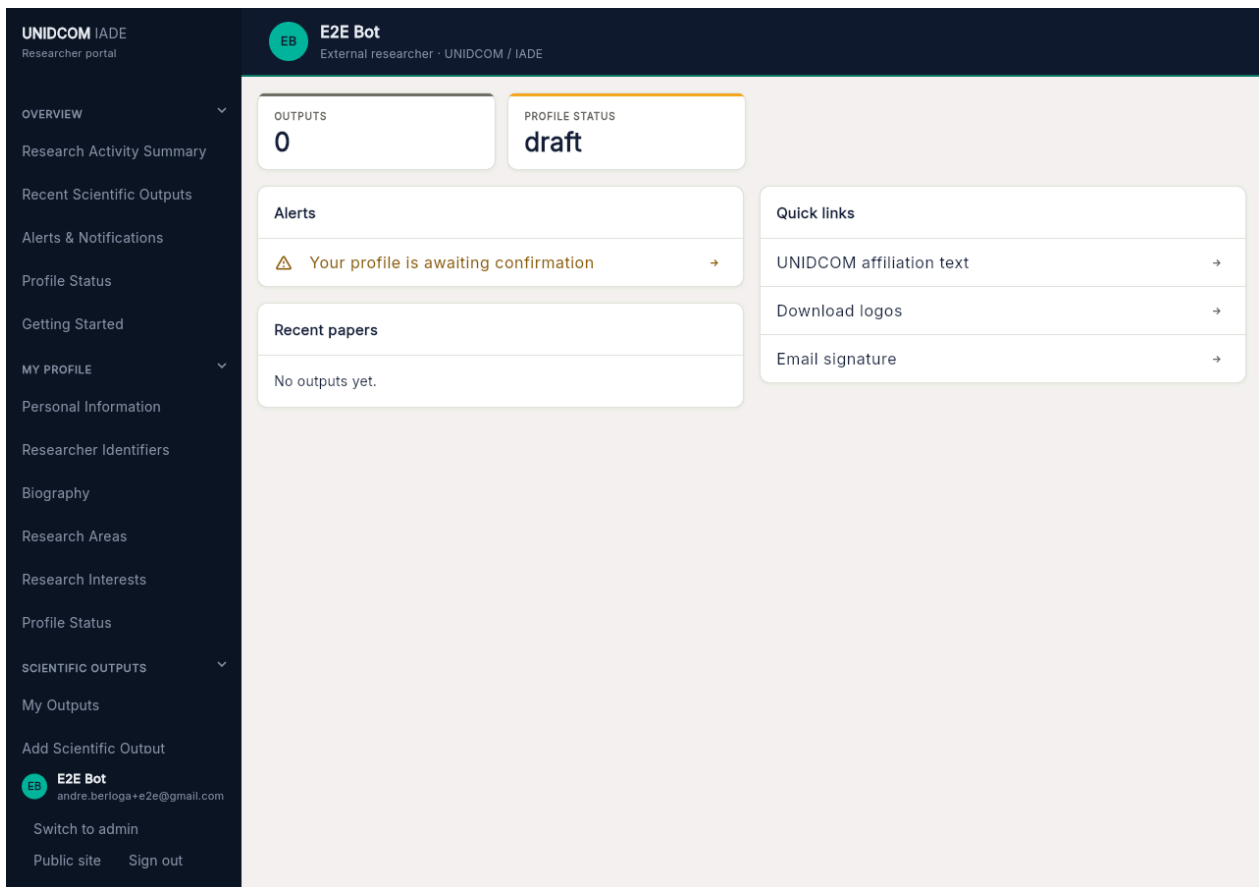


Figure 1: Researcher home at 1280 × 900. The sidebar shown here has no accessibility nodes (F-001); “Add Scientific Output” is cut off behind the footer (F-035); the status tile shows the raw value `draft` (F-016).